

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

◀ PRIYA SAROJ, *25*

| SP | *Machhlishahr (SC), UP*

A law graduate, Priya was content practising in the Supreme Court till the Samajwadi Party invested its hope in young talent like her to overturn the BJP's hold on the state. Daughter of three-time MP Toofani Saroj, who represented Saidpur twice and Machhlishahr after the former constituency was abolished, Priya had assisted her father in the 2022 assembly election campaign. Familiar with the heat and dust of electoral politics, Priya delivered on her party's expectations by defeating BJP heavyweight B.P. Saroj. Now, she says, she will work towards women's empowerment and creating employment opportunities for the youth.

PUSHPENDRA SAROJ, *25* ▼

| SP | *Kaushambi (SC), UP*

Three months and three days over the minimum qualifying age of 25 for a Lok Sabha election on June 4, to him belongs the honour of being the youngest MP in the 18th Lok Sabha. Part of Akhilesh's young brigade, Saroj is among those who've helped the party emerge as the third-largest in the lower house. An accounts and management graduate from the Queen Mary University of London, he defeated sitting BJP MP Vinod Kumar Sonkar by a lakh-plus votes, avenging the loss his father, senior SP leader Indrajeet Saroj, suffered here in 2019.



Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH



SHAMBHAVI, *26* ▶

| LOK JANSHAKTI PARTY (Ram Vilas) | *Samastipur (SC), Bihar*

Her grandfather, Mahavir Choudhary, was a nine-time Congress MLA. Her father Ashok Choudhary is in the Janata Dal (United) minister in the Nitish Kumar government. Shambhavi, though, chose to go with Chirag Paswan's Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas), the party her father-in-law, the former IPS officer, philanthropist and scholar Acharya Kishore Kunal, is close to. A graduate from LSR College, Shambhavi studied Sociology at the Delhi School of Economics and pursued a doctorate on the "Intersectionality of Gender and Caste in Bihar Politics". Having now won the SC seat, Shambhavi will have a chance to put that education to good use. She has already drawn up a roadmap for what she wants to do to better her state—infrastructure and roads, to begin with.

–Prashant Srivastava, Rohit Parihar, Ajay Sukumaran and Amitabh Srivastava